Biriuzov had accomplished the first part of his task, getting Castro on board. The other part of his mission was to determine whether the missiles could be deployed in Cuba without being detected by the Americans. On May 31, the day after receiving Fidel's approval, Biriuzov joined Raúl Castro, who served as the Cuban minister of defense, to survey sites for possible missile deployment. Raúl now learned that the missiles to be delivered to Cuba were to be 20 meters long (the R-12 was in fact more than 22 meters long, and the length of the R-14 exceeded 24 meters). He later shared his doubts with Fidel that they could be hidden effectively from American view. But Biriuzov, who saw plainly that Cuban palms could not possibly hide missile installations covering hundreds of square meters, seemed unconcerned.[23]

General Gribkov, one of the key planners of Operation Anadyr who came to Cuba in the fall of 1962, saw the lack of natural cover for himself and later lamented "the conclusion, striking in its strategic illiteracy, that missiles could easily and secretly be deployed in Cuba, as there were … many palm groves there." As it did not behoove Gribkov to criticize his military superior, Biriuzov, he blamed the "specialists" from the Rashidov group instead. Khrushchev had sent Biriuzov to Cuba to make sure that Operation Anadyr would go ahead. He might have considered raising the camouflage problem had Castro refused Khrushchev's proposal, but the Cuban leader accepted it, and Biriuzov probably felt that he had no choice. He returned to Moscow to report good news on both counts: Castro's agreement and the suitability of Cuban terrain for concealing the missiles.[24]

Biriuzov spoke to the Central Committee Presidium on June 10. After he finished his report, Khrushchev took the podium. The terse notes of the meeting record the gist of his remarks as follows: "Proceed to deciding the question. I think that we will win this operation." It was a victory for Khrushchev and a setback for his main opponent on the issue, Anastas Mikoyan. "Castro gave his consent, and the Cuban landscape was found to be suitable for camouflaging the missiles," he recalled later. "I did not believe that conclusion." Meanwhile, the jubilant Khrushchev wrote to Castro expressing his satisfaction with the results of the delegation's visit and Castro's acceptance of the missiles. This would "mean a further fortification of the victory of the Cuban revolution and of the greater